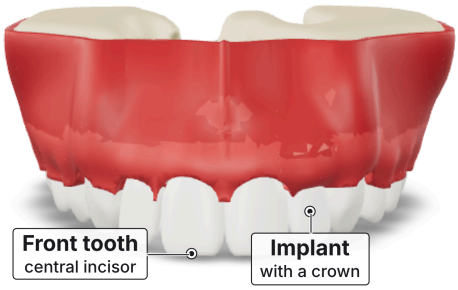
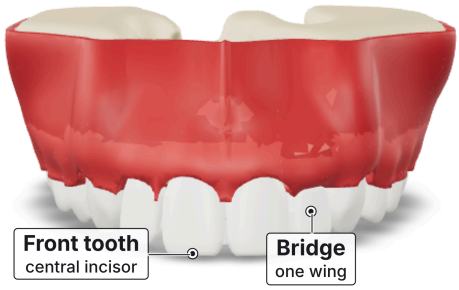
Stage 3: Braces off

Bone graft for a cleft in the gum: the three stages

This model shows the same jaw in the later teens, after the braces come off. Your dentist can now fill the gap where the small tooth never grew.



Implant with a crown



Bridge with one wing

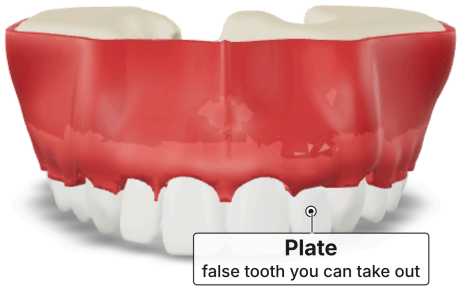
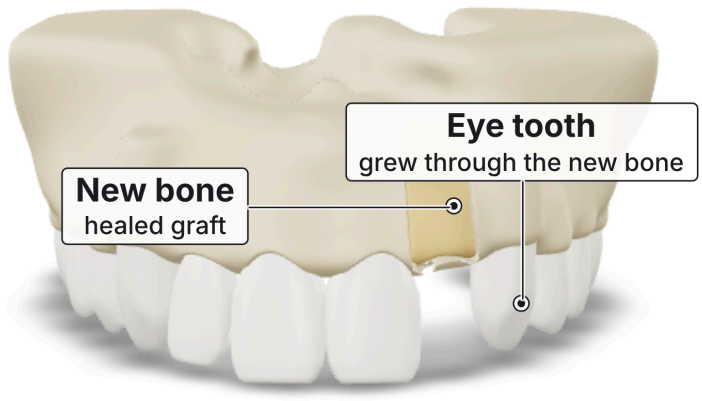
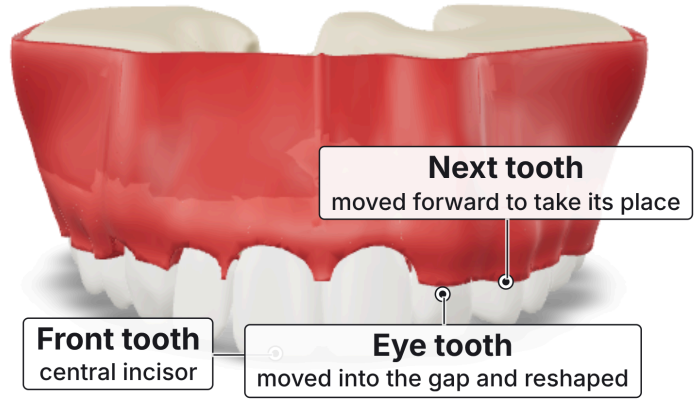


Plate with a false tooth



Gum taken off: the new bone where the gap was



Space closed: the eye tooth moved into the gap

What has changed

The braces are off, and the teeth are in line. Bone holds the teeth where the gap was.[1,2]

You have stopped growing, so your dentist can now fill the gap for good.[3,4]

Ways to fill the gap

There are three main ways to fill the gap:[3]

- an **implant**: a small post in the new bone with a false tooth (a **crown**) on top[4]
- a **bridge**: a false tooth with one wing glued to the back of the front tooth
- a **plate you can take out** (a partial denture). The small plate sits behind the teeth and holds the false tooth with hidden clips.

The pictures show each choice.

Some teams close the space instead. Braces move the eye tooth into the place of the missing tooth. Then the dentist re-shapes it so it looks like the missing tooth. Many teams use this plan for children with a cleft. The last picture shows this plan.[5,1,6,7]

Your cleft team will talk with you about which plan suits you.[3]

Sources **1.** Bergland O, Semb G, Abyholm FE. Elimination of the residual alveolar cleft by secondary bone grafting and subsequent orthodontic treatment. Cleft Palate J. 1986;23:175-205. PMID 3524905. pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/3524905 **2.** Jahanbin A, et al. Long-term stability of alveolar bone graft in cleft lip and palate: a systematic review and meta-analysis. J Craniofac Surg. 2022;33:e194-e200. doi.org/10.1097/SCS.0000000000008254 **3.** Clerc MM, et al. Replacement of missing lateral incisors for patients with cleft lip and palate: a decision-making tree based on a systematic review. J Prosthet Dent. 2025;134:50-60. doi.org/10.1016/j.prosdent.2023.07.023 **4.** Knobloch LA, et al. Narrow diameter implants for a missing lateral incisor in cleft palate patients: five-year results. J Prosthet Dent. 2025;134:1738-1747. doi.org/10.1016/j.prosdent.2024.07.048 **5.** Lee A, et al. Dental rehabilitation of the unilateral cleft dental gap: long-term follow-up. J Craniofac Surg. 2024;35:199-202. doi.org/10.1097/SCS.0000000000009802 **6.** Kokich VO Jr, Kinzer GA. Managing congenitally missing lateral incisors. Part I: canine substitution. J Esthet Restor Dent. 2005;17:5-10. doi.org/10.1111/j.1708-8240.2005.tb00076.x **7.** Zachrisson BU, Rosa M, Toreskog S. Congenitally missing maxillary lateral incisors: canine substitution. Am J Orthod Dentofacial Orthop. 2011;139:434-438. doi.org/10.1016/j.ajodo.2011.02.003

This sheet is for a study at Aichi Gakuin University and Nagoya University. Version 0.2, 4 November 2026.